Zoning Approach to Olympics/Paralympics Construction

September, 2025

Issue:

LA28 and the Olympic Committee are proposing to build a turf course for the Cross Country Equestrian event as well as Dressage and Show Jumping Facilities at Santa Anita. The Cross Country course must be between 5 to 6.8 Kilometers long and have a specific number of jumps and obstacles. This will require use of the majority of the north parking lot at Santa Anita, as well as portions of the existing turf course, and sloped area behind the existing "down the hill" turf chute. Additional facilities will need to be constructed within the infield for the other events.

The facilities must be completed by Summer 2027, one full year before the Olympics and Paralympics, in order to do a "test event" that will clear the course for Olympic Use.

Question:

What will the Zoning / Entitlement / Approval process be?

Zoning Context

All of the area proposed for the event course falls with Santa Anita Park property. The majority of the Santa Anita Park site falls within the "S-1" zone, or Racetrack Special Use Zone. Portions of the North Parking lot up to and including the existing down-the-hill turf chute fall within the "RTE" or Race Track Event Overlay Zone, which has some of its own requirements but ties itself to the S-1 zone and primarily addresses Special Events in the north parking lot. The RTE zone also covers the southernmost portion of the parking lot along Huntington Drive.

The very north part of the racetrack property is zoned R-1. This is the area between the down-the-hill turf chute and the residential property above and is sloped for the most part. The two attached maps show the zoning.

Land Use Determination

The Purpose and Intent of the S-1 (Racetrack Special Use Zone) is as follows:

- **9102.07.010 - Purpose and Intent.**

  The Special Use (S-1) zone is intended to provide for the continued operation of the Santa Anita Racetrack and to allow for horseracing, related activities, and authorized special events. This zone implements the General Plan Horse Racing designation.

The equestrian events for the Olympic and Paralympic Games clearly fall into the purpose and Intent of the zone as horseracing and/or related activities. Further, within the S-1 zone, the following land uses are also permitted outright, all of which are similar to what the Olympic events provide:

- Daytime Sports/Athletic Events – Permitted outright
- Horse Breeding, Training, and Shows – Permitted outright
- Assembly/Meeting Facilities – Permitted outright

In addition to the categories listed above, the S-1 zone also includes the section below related to Director Determinations.

9102.07.020 (B) Director Determination. Land uses are defined in Division 9 (Definitions). In cases where a specific land use or activity is not defined, the Director shall assign the land use or activity to a classification substantially similar in character. Land uses not listed in the table or not found to be substantially similar to the land uses below are prohibited.

Clearly, the equestrian event uses could be assigned to all of the above classifications. As such, event construction falls with the Permitted outright category and is within the purpose and intent of the zone. Therefore, construction would be required to pull ministerial permits for course construction and related facility construction (e.g. building permits, grading permits, etc.) only. There would be no discretionary review for these activities. This is the same approach that has been taken for many years at Santa Anita relative to changes in racing surface material, expansion of turf and dirt track facilities, the addition of the flat turf chute in recent years, etc. This determination would not necessarily apply to permanent structures or lighting in the north parking lot, which may be subject to Site Plan and Design Review.

Development Standards in the S-1 zone

The only relevant Development Standards are as follows:

Additional Setbacks.

- **Huntington Drive Setback.** Other than service/fueling stations, no building or structure shall be located closer than 150 feet to the outside edge of the Huntington Drive right-of-way.
- **Setback for Stables.** No stable or other building or structure for the shelter of horses or other animals shall be located within 250 feet of any public street or highway.

Race Track Event Overlay Zone

With regard to property in the RTE Overlay Zone, the purpose of this zone is to regulate activities on the Santa Anita Park property so that they do not adversely impact adjacent properties zoned for residential use. Specifically, the zone exists to regulate special or temporary events. The Olympics construction is NOT classified as a special or temporary event. It is being classified as construction related to horse racing and related activities. Therefore, the use would be permitted in this area in the same fashion as it is in the S-1 zone.

However, the City's role is to protect the residential property in the area, mitigate impacts and issues, and ensure that these properties are not adversely impacted. To this end, the RTE zone has the following standard which could be incorporated:

C. Restriction on Development Standards. No equipment or apparatus shall be placed or maintained within 100 feet of any adjacent residentially-zoned property line.

The regulation above could be interpreted to mean permanent structures or apparatus only. For example, if a jump for the cross country course, or a camera pole or structure was placed temporarily, this could be judged to be compliant, as long as it was removed. It is unknown at this time whether any "equipment or apparatus" is to be placed with 100 feet of residential properties. The course itself certainly will, but this is just groundcover.

R-1 Zone

The area north of the turf chute is zoned R-1. While it is zoned R-1, it is within the Horse Racing General Plan designation, and it is within the Santa Anita Park property. A portion of the area is currently used for horse racing related activities and will continue to be used as such. The same "Director Determination" language listed above also applies to the R-1 zone.

Again, the key is protecting the residentially zoned property to the north and mitigating impacts. This will be a key part of this effort and the Olympic Construction will be subject to an Impact Mitigation and Neighborhood Compatibility Plan (the name of this can change) that will cover the following issues, at a minimum:

- Noise (Construction and Operations)
- Dust Management
- Drainage
- Erosion Control
- Tree Protection and Preservation
- Aesthetics
- Setbacks and Visual Barriers
- Pest Management

Required Permits and Processes

- Building, Grading, Electrical, and/or Plumbing permits are required for all construction.
- Impact Mitigation and Neighborhood Compatibility Plan is required to be approved before construction begins.
- With regard to PERMANENT new structures, the Code states the following:

Applicability and Authority. *Structures erected or modified to accommodate the land use activities listed in Division 2 (Zones, Allowable Uses, and Development Standards), including issuance of a building permit or sign permit, approval or conditional approval of a conditional use permit, variance or modification with respect to any and all exterior alterations, additions and new construction, installation of exterior lighting for the infield and parking areas, and installation of perimeter and parking lot landscaping and signing improvements, shall require the approval of a Site Plan and Design Review subject to the requirements of Section 9107.19 (Site Plan and Design Review) of this Development Code and this Section. In the S-1 Zone, the review and approval, conditional approval or disapproval shall be by the Commission and Council, except as noted in Subsection 9102.07.040.C (Administrative Design Review). The provisions of this Section shall not apply to building permits for work which is located entirely within a building and which does not alter the external appearance of the building.*